The Tale of Custard the Dragon

The big idea

The Tale of Custard the Dragon by **Ogden Nash** is a funny **ballad** about a "cowardly" pet dragon who turns out to be the bravest of all when a pirate attacks — while the "brave" pets run away. It shows that **true courage** is shown in action, not in boasting.

Characters

Character	Who	Boast vs reality
Belinda	a little girl in a little white house	"brave as a barrel full of bears", but cries "Help! Help!" at the pirate
Ink	a little black **kitten**	boasts, but hides at the bottom of the household
Blink	a little grey **mouse**	hides in a mousehole
Mustard	a little yellow **dog**	"brave as a tiger in a rage", but runs away with a yelp
Custard	a little pet **dragon**	called a coward, cries for a "nice safe cage", but fights and eats the pirate

Summary

1. Custard has big sharp teeth, spikes on top, scales underneath, a mouth like a fireplace, a chimney for a nose and **daggers** for toes — yet he is considered a coward.

2. Belinda, Ink, Blink and Mustard boast of their bravery and tease Custard, tickling him unmercifully and calling him **"Percival"**.
3. One day a **pirate** climbs in through the window with pistols in both hands and a cutlass in his teeth.
4. Everyone else panics and runs. **Custard** jumps up, snorting like an engine, clashing his tail like irons in a dungeon, and **gobbles up the pirate**.
5. Belinda embraces Custard and Mustard licks him; nobody mourns the pirate.
6. Soon the others start boasting again — Mustard says he would have been twice as brave if he had not been so dizzy; Ink and Blink claim they would have been three times as brave. Custard still admits he is cowardly and wants a nice safe cage.

IRONY

The "cowardly" dragon is the only real hero; the "brave" ones are cowards who keep boasting. Custard is also **humble** — he never boasts.

Poetic devices

- **Ballad:** a story told in verse with simple rhyme and rhythm.
- **Rhyme scheme: aabb** (couplets) — e.g. house/mouse.
- **Simile:** "brave as a barrel full of bears"; "brave as a tiger in a rage"; "mouth like a fireplace"; "snorting like an engine"; "clashed his tail like irons in a dungeon".
- **Metaphor:** "chimney for a nose", "daggers for toes".
- **Alliteration:** "**b**rave as a **b**arrel full of **b**ears"; "**l**ittle ... **l**ived".
- **Repetition** and **coined words:** "**realio, trulio**, little pet dragon"; "**mouseholed**".
- **Onomatopoeia:** "**clatter**", "**clank**", "**jangling**" as Custard charges "like a robin at a worm" (another simile).
- **Humour** and **irony** throughout.

NAMES

Ink = kitten, **Blink** = mouse, **Mustard** = dog, **Custard** = dragon. Don't mix them up!

Message and value points

- Real bravery is shown when danger comes, not in words.
- Humble people may be the true heroes; boasting is hollow.
- Don't judge others by appearance or reputation.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Who were Belinda's pets? Why was Custard called a coward? How did Custard fight the pirate? What is ironic about the poem? Find similes and the rhyme scheme.

Quick recap

- Ogden Nash; ballad; aabb.
- Belinda + Ink (kitten), Blink (mouse), Mustard (dog), Custard (dragon).
- Pirate attacks; boasters flee; Custard eats the pirate.
- The boasters boast again — irony; true courage vs empty boasting.

Practice questions

1. Who was Ink?
   (a) A mouse (b) A little black kitten (c) A yellow dog (d) The dragon
2. Why did everyone tease Custard?
   (a) He was small (b) He was ugly (c) He was considered a coward and cried for a nice safe cage (d) He ate too much
3. What did Custard do when the pirate came?
   (a) He hid in a cage (b) He ran away (c) He called for help (d) He attacked and ate the pirate
4. "Brave as a barrel full of bears" is an example of
   (a) simile and alliteration (b) metaphor only (c) personification (d) onomatopoeia
5. What is the rhyme scheme of the poem?
   (a) abab (b) abcb (c) aabb (d) free verse
6. The main irony of the poem is that
   (a) the pirate was a friend (b) Belinda was a dragon (c) the "coward" is the real hero while the "brave" ones run away (d) Mustard ate the pirate
7. What did Mustard say after the pirate was eaten?
   (a) He thanked Custard (b) He would have been twice as brave if he had not been so dizzy (c) He was afraid (d) He wanted to be a dragon
8. Compare the behaviour of Custard with that of the other pets. What message does the poem give?

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. d 4. a 5. c 6. c 7. b 8. see notes